

AUSTRALASIA AND OCEANIA

THIS VAST ISLAND REGION is spread over a huge area of the Pacific Ocean to the south of Southeast Asia. Australasia is made up of Australia, New Zealand, Papua New Guinea, and several nearby islands. Australia is the only country that is also a continent in its own right, the smallest of the seven. Australasia is often linked with three groups of Pacific islands – Melanesia, Micronesia, and Polynesia – which form an even wider region, called Oceania. The climate and geography of Australasia and Oceania are as diverse as the region itself, ranging from the rain forests of northern Australia and the glaciers of southern New Zealand, to the coral atolls and volcanoes that form many of the Pacific islands.



PAPUA NEW GUINEA

Papua New Guinea is the eastern end of the island of New Guinea. The western end is called Papua (Irian Jaya), part of Indonesia. Papua New Guinea is a country of high mountains and thick forests. The highest peak, Mount Wilhelm, reaches 14,107 ft (4,300 m) and is often snow-capped, despite lying close to the Equator. Lower down, the climate is hot and humid, ideal for the growth of the rich, tropical rain forests that cover two-thirds of the island.



The frilled lizard lives in the deserts of the outback.

THE AUSTRALIAN OUTBACK

Australia has four major deserts – the Simpson, Gibson, Great Sandy, and Great Victoria. Together they cover most of the heart of the continent in a vast, barren area known as the outback. Very few people live in the outback, although the dry conditions are good for raising sheep and cattle.

